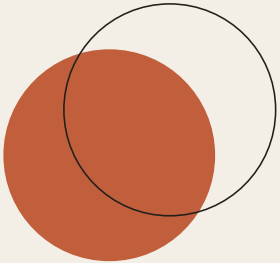
November 6, 2026

Research with AI Agents

What Works, What It Costs, and What an Institute Needs

Lukas Theissinger



Outline

I. OpenAI and Agent Usage

II. Owning Intelligence and Infrastructure at Lamarr

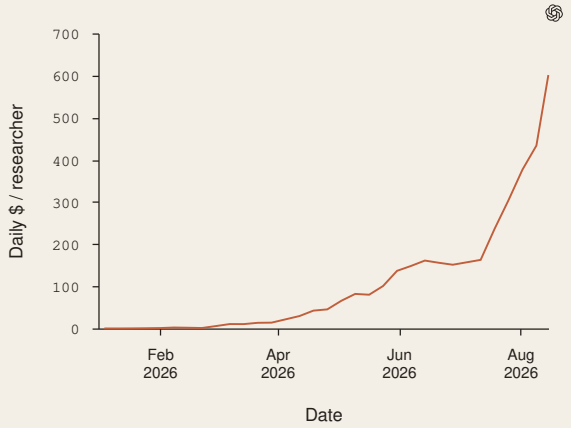


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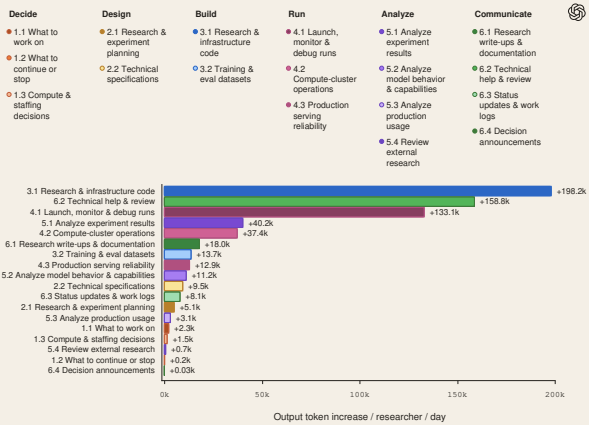
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FOMO Headline: OpenAI Agent Usage



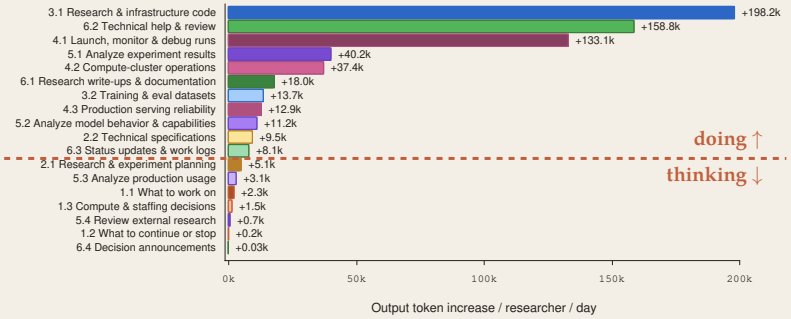
Median researcher, daily $ spent on internal coding agents. Source: OpenAI, "Research acceleration" (self-reported)

What do agents do at OpenAI?



Increase in output tokens per researcher per day, by research activity. Source: OpenAI, "Research acceleration" (self-reported)

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What the OpenAI chart suggests

All 18 activities went up: agents are used everywhere, but how much and how exactly is still open

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Did agents take over the *thinking*? We can't say: a plan or a decision is short, so tokens are the wrong measure	Agent use is a *skill*: not everything can or should be automated (degree of automation)

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Field Report: Automating Exercises

1. **The problem.** PhD student, tutoring an exercise class every two weeks:
   - 2 h exercise class + 6 h preparation (solving the tasks, making the slides)
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4. **Ask your agent to try it:** `github.com/Newida/AutomatingExercises` **Avoid:** Don't do anything BY HAND on this project. If you want to change it, ASK YOUR AGENT to change it

II

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Example: travel expense reports

Collect receipts, fill in the university form, look up per-diem rules, fix what admin sends back: say **3 trips** × **3 h per person per year**. An agent that reads the receipts and files the form correctly needs ∼**200 h** (rules, forms, access to the admin system)

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institute, 10 000 people	$10\,000 \times 9\,\text{h} = 90\,000\,\text{h/year}$	200 h	**pays >400×**

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A request to management: right now, many of us pay for these tools ourselves. Most of us stop at the 20 € plan rather than the 100 € one, so we get less out of the tools than we could. Institutional access would help us do better work and it will matter more and more for attracting and keeping good people, as other institutes, in Germany and abroad, start to provide it

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So let's talk about costs

Decision 1: Subscription or API?

Subscription (20–200 €/month)

+ flat price, no surprise bills
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Our comparison: one month of my usage, priced at API list prices

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Rule of thumb: people → subscription; pipelines and batch jobs → API

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Small open models are clearly behind. The largest open models are much closer to the frontier; on our tasks they are **still untested**

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Quality and performance

+ data never leaves Lamarr (privacy, unpublished work, GDPR)
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ROUGH COMPARISON

2 nodes × 300 k€ over 4 years ≈ 12.5 k€/month ≈ **300 people** × **40 €** ≈ **125 people** × **100 €**

With Lamarr's compute, a frontier-class open model for everyone is realistic: it pays off through privacy, scale and no caps; the closed models keep a lead of months

Field Report: Self-Hosting in Practice

Main model: GLM-5.3-Flash, 45 days

	45 days	per month
input tokens	28.3 B	∼19 B
of it cached	25.4 B (90 %)	
output tokens	585 M	∼390 M
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Takeaway

Running the model is cheap (energy ≪ API bill). The real costs are the hardware [?] and the expert who keeps it running

Takeaways

For the individual

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   Learn by doing, tailor it to your workflow, and make your daily work easier

For the institute

1. **Automate workflows for every individual:** what never pays off for one person pays off for 10 000
2. **Provide your employees with agents**
3. **Consider self-hosting**

Next: David's Setup

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2. David shows **his own setup**: how it looks in daily work for him

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1. We know that we **need AI agents** and what to use them for
2. David shows **his own setup**: how it looks in daily work for him
3. The best setup is **personal and custom**, so build your own